

Divorce is 73. Getting married is 50, and getting back together again is 45. Getting fired is 47 and retiring is 45. And so on down the list. Score over 300 in any twelve-month period, Dr. Holmes found, and you have an 80 percent chance of winding up on your back within two years. To put it another way, when you lose control of your life, you get sick.

One way to get control of your life is to retire. After a few months your retired life settles into a rhythm, and you feel more in control than you ever thought possible.

But before you hit that rhythm you face a transition, a draining period of choosing between options. Every day brings the unknown, the untried, and the unusual. You need to commit yourself to weaving through the possibilities. You need to:

Manage the change

Toffler defines “future shock” as what we feel in the face of great change. “Future shock absorbers” help us get through it.

One future shock absorber is to view change as a normal, routine part of life rather than as the exception. We tend to view life as a sequence of periods of stability interrupted by windows of change. Toffler says we’re better off to view life as a sequence of periods of change interrupted by windows of stability. With this view, change becomes the norm and is easier to handle.

Another future shock absorber is to keep something stable in our lives. Simple items like a favorite coffee cup, grandma’s necklace, or a notebook can make us feel at home in a sterile hotel room. We should refuse, when practicable, to buy throw-away clothes, disposable cigarette lighters, paper plates, and the like.

Another future shock absorber is to anticipate and identify with change. The two-year test helps you do that. You look out two years, imagine yourself retired, and begin to design